Spaces with a Soul

SHIMONA BHANSALI, 42
Founder and Principal Designer, DesignHex
Mumbai

WOMAN TO WOMAN

"We are often taught to prove that we deserve a seat at the table. I think the more interesting question is, what if you changed the table itself?"



KUBER SHAH

Shimona Bhansali loves curved forms and dramatic designs, something that mirrors her non-linear career trajectory. At just 17, while most teenagers were navigating high school, she took on her first independent design project. After completing her management studies in 2005, she began doing interiors as a hobby for close family and friends. Her real education was forged on the ground—through drawing, carpentry and other artistic disciplines rather than a formal design school. At the same time, she launched a packaging company and ran it successfully, only to realise that it was merely a detour before the pull of three-dimensional spaces became impossible to ignore. In 2016, she formally founded DesignHex.

Treating every early commission as a testing ground for her multi-functional philosophy, Shimona has quietly built a reputation over the years. Even today, the creative ethos of her firm rests on a simple sentiment: "It feels good to be lost in the right spaces." That idea also underpins her rejection of the beige minimalism that has come to dominate many Indian homes.

Today, she stands out as an outspoken, unapologetic, maximalist-loving designer whose work is synonymous with over-the-top spaces. Think hand-painted ocean ceilings, Antoni Gaudí-inspired structures, and homes designed as vibrant ecosystems that could house a chorus of exotic birds. Yet what distinguishes her work is not merely its abundance, but the sharp, contrarian language of her design. A former WADE Asia (Women in Architecture and Design) and GeeVees award winner, this year she also features in 'AHJ 26of26', Architecture Home Journal's annual edition dedicated to the 26 most compelling architects and designers from all over the world.

For now, Bansal remains grounded and curious. "I admire people who remain beginners even after becoming experts. The moment you think you have figured everything out, you stop growing." ■

—Ridhi Kale

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Rejecting cookie-cutter aesthetics, Shimona has built a thriving interior design practice that has brought her top awards, including the WADE prize for women in 2024 and a GeeVees award in 2025